“People see my difference before they see me.”

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Where it often comes from

First impressions are fast and often shaped by what is visible. Repeated experiences of being pigeonholed lead us to expect it always.

What Scripture teaches

God said to Samuel, “Man sees the outward appearance, but the LORD sees the heart.” Jesus saw people as individuals: Bartimaeus, a blind beggar, was called by name and asked, “What do you want Me to do for you?” (Mark 10:51). “Stop judging by outward appearances, and start judging justly” (John 7:24). Some people will notice first and then look deeper. Others will meet you directly, and over time, those who matter see the whole you.

> *“But the LORD said to Samuel, ‘Do not consider his appearance or height, for I have rejected him; the LORD does not see as man does. For man sees the outward appearance, but the LORD sees the heart.’”* (1 Samuel 16:7).

Also see

> “Next, they came to Jericho. And as Jesus and His disciples were leaving Jericho with a large crowd, a blind beggar named Bartimaeus, the son of Timaeus, was sitting beside the road” (Mark 10:46).

> “Stop judging by outward appearances, and start judging justly” (John 7:24).

> “Now this is what the LORD says— He who created you, O Jacob, and He who formed you, O Israel: ‘Do not fear, for I have redeemed you; I have called you by your name; you are Mine!’” (Isaiah 43:1).

> “O LORD, You have searched me and known me” (Psalm 139:1).

Common self-statements

- It is all they see.
- I will always be defined by it.
- They never see the real me.
- First impressions are final.
- I am a walking difference.
- No one gets past it.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing people see only my difference or only me.
- Fortune telling: Predicting that people will never look deeper.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling noticed and concluding I am defined.
- Mind reading: Calling myself my difference.

Challenging questions

- Who has looked past my difference?
- What do I want people to know first?

- How do I introduce myself?
- What does it feel like when someone sees me fully?
- What does God see?
- What conversation starters let people see more of me?

Truth summary

> God sees my heart, and many people will, too. I can guide first impressions by sharing what matters about me, and I can seek those who look deeper.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Friendship
- Judgmental
- Prejudice
- Loneliness

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Love

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Praise You in This Storm — Casting Crowns featuring Phil Wickham
Suffering and tears do not establish that God is absent or uncaring.

I Am Not Alone — Kari Jobe
God's companionship remains through darkness, weakness, and uncertainty.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

My Plan for Replacing "People see my difference before they see me"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"People see my difference before they see me." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who has looked past my difference?
- ☐ What do I want people to know first?
- ☐ How do I introduce myself?
- ☐ What does it feel like when someone sees me fully?
- ☐ What does God see?
- ☐ What conversation starters let people see more of me?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ The Lord sees my heart.
- ☐ Jesus saw individuals.
- ☐ Many people look deeper.
- ☐ I can lead with who I am.
- ☐ I am known by name.
- ☐ I am more than my difference.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ 1 Samuel 16:7
  "But the LORD said to Samuel, 'Do not consider his appearance or height, for I have rejected him; the LORD does not see as man does. For man sees the outward appearance, but the LORD sees the heart.'"
- ☐ Mark 10:46
  "Next, they came to Jericho. And as Jesus and His disciples were leaving Jericho with a large crowd, a blind beggar named Bartimaeus, the son of Timaeus, was sitting beside the road."
- ☐ John 7:24
  "Stop judging by outward appearances, and start judging justly."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Seen for me: Each week, note one person who saw more than your difference.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, 1 Samuel 16:7 becomes: "Sarah can write: "The Lord sees my heart.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Judgmental" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

These cards support emotional and spiritual care and do not replace medical care. Follow your doctor's advice about treatment and medication, and choose steps that are safe for your body. In an emergency call 911; for thoughts of self-harm call or text 988 (U.S.).

- [ ] Plan an intro. Share an interest or strength early.
- [ ] Thank deep seers. Tell someone they see you.
- [ ] Join an interest group. Meet people around shared passions.
- [ ] Read Mark 10:46–52. Notice how Jesus engaged.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "People see my difference before they see me": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Seen for me
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~People see my difference before they see me.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, people notice my difference first. Thank You that You see my heart. Give me friends who see all of me. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.